

PACIFIC MEDICAL EVALUATORS, INC.

Independent Medical Examination Services
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INDEPENDENT MEDICAL EXAMINATION REPORT

EXAMINATION INFORMATION

Examinee: Maria Elena Santos
Date of Birth: March 14, 1988
Date of Examination: April 15, 2024
Date of Injury: February 8, 2024
Examiner: Richard Stevenson, MD
Specialty: Orthopedic Surgery
Requesting Party: Hartford Insurance Company
Claim Number: HRT-2024-0892147

PURPOSE OF EXAMINATION

This independent medical examination was requested by Hartford Insurance Company to address the following:

1. Current diagnosis and medical status
2. Causation of current conditions
3. Maximum Medical Improvement (MMI) status
4. Permanent impairment rating, if applicable
5. Appropriateness of current treatment
6. Work capacity and restrictions
7. Future medical needs

RECORDS REVIEWED

- Riverside General Hospital ER records (02/08/2024)
- Dr. Kevin Park orthopedic records (02/10/2024, 03/08/2024)
- Dr. Sarah Goldstein neurology consultation (02/12/2024)
- Riverside Imaging Center MRI report (02/15/2024)
- ProMotion Physical Therapy records (02/19/2024 - 04/01/2024)
- Employer incident report
- OSHA investigation report

HISTORY AS OBTAINED FROM EXAMINEE

Ms. Santos is a 35-year-old right-hand dominant female who reports she was working as a carpenter for Titan Construction when she fell approximately 15 feet from scaffolding on February 8, 2024. She states the scaffolding was missing guardrails and the plank shifted beneath her. She denies any loss of consciousness.

She reports her current symptoms include:

- Intermittent low back pain, rated 3/10 on average
- Occasional left leg tingling with prolonged sitting
- Right wrist stiffness, particularly in the morning
- Reduced grip strength in right hand
- No current headaches or cognitive complaints

PHYSICAL EXAMINATION

General: Well-developed, well-nourished female in no acute distress. Alert and cooperative.

Right Wrist/Hand:

- Healed surgical scar from ER laceration repair
- Mild residual swelling over distal radius
- ROM: Flexion 55° (normal 80°), Extension 50° (normal 70°)
- Grip strength: 18 kg (left 32 kg) - 56% of contralateral
- Sensation intact
- No instability

Lumbar Spine:

- Gait: Normal, no antalgic pattern
- ROM: Flexion 70°, Extension 25°, Lateral flexion 30° bilaterally
- Palpation: Mild tenderness L4-L5 paraspinals
- SLR: Negative bilaterally
- Neurological: Motor 5/5, Sensation intact, Reflexes 2+ symmetric

Cognitive: Alert, oriented, appropriate. No evidence of ongoing post-concussion syndrome.

DIAGNOSES

1. Healed right distal radius fracture with residual stiffness
2. Resolved concussion
3. L4-L5 disc herniation, improving, with resolved radiculopathy
4. Lumbar strain/sprain, resolved

DISCUSSION AND OPINIONS

1. Causation

It is my opinion, to a reasonable degree of medical certainty, that the right wrist fracture and concussion are **directly caused** by the workplace fall of February 8, 2024.

Regarding the lumbar disc herniation at L4-L5, the mechanism of injury (15-foot fall onto concrete) is consistent with acute disc injury. While the MRI noted “mild degenerative changes,” which may have been pre-existing, the symptomatic disc herniation with radiculopathy is **more likely than not causally related** to the workplace injury, or at minimum, the injury caused a significant aggravation of any pre-existing condition.

2. Maximum Medical Improvement

The concussion has resolved. The patient is at MMI for this condition.

The right wrist fracture has healed, but the patient has residual stiffness and weakness. Given that she is still in occupational therapy, I would estimate she will reach MMI for the wrist in approximately **4-6 weeks**.

The lumbar spine has shown significant improvement with physical therapy. The radiculopathy has resolved. She may reach MMI for the lumbar condition in approximately **6-8 weeks**.

3. Permanent Impairment

Using the AMA Guides to the Evaluation of Permanent Impairment, 5th Edition:

Condition	Estimated WPI
Right Wrist (if current deficits persist)	5-7%
Lumbar Spine (DRE Category II)	5-8%
Concussion	0%
Combined Estimate	10-14%

Note: Final impairment rating should be deferred until MMI is reached.

4. Current Treatment

The physical therapy and occupational therapy are **reasonable and necessary**. The treatment frequency and duration are appropriate for her injuries.

5. Work Capacity

Currently, Ms. Santos can perform **sedentary to light duty work** with the following restrictions:

- No lifting over 15 lbs with right hand
- No repetitive gripping with right hand
- Ability to change positions every 30-45 minutes
- No climbing ladders or scaffolding
- No work at heights

I anticipate she **can return to full duty** construction work in approximately **8-12 weeks** if she continues to progress as expected.

6. Future Medical Care

- Complete current course of physical therapy (6-8 more weeks)
- Complete current course of occupational therapy (4-6 more weeks)
- Possible need for 1-2 cortisone injections if symptoms plateau
- Low probability of requiring lumbar surgery given current improvement
- Annual follow-up orthopedic visits for 1-2 years

SUMMARY

Ms. Santos sustained legitimate injuries from her February 8, 2024 workplace fall including a right wrist fracture, concussion, and lumbar disc herniation. She has made good progress with treatment. She is not yet at MMI but is expected to reach MMI in approximately 2-3 months. Anticipated permanent impairment is in the range of 10-14% whole person. She should be able to return to full duty work within 8-12 weeks.

I declare under penalty of perjury that the information contained in this report is true and correct to the best of my knowledge.

Richard Stevenson, MD

Board Certified Orthopedic Surgery

CA Medical License #A-XXXXX

Date: April 15, 2024